of Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) added "India's has demonstrated consistent capability in delivering on low-cost and high-quality medical research, while also maintaining technical and scientific rigour. This partnership signifies yet another step in India's efforts to bolster the fight against this global pandemic." Bharat Biotech began clinical testing of its indigenously developed vaccine in September last year, after announcing a series of partnerships for co-developing vaccines with American research institutions. In January 2020, the DGCI gave Covishield and Covaxin were given approval for restricted use in emergency situation, at the same time giving Cadila Healthcare permission to continue to phase III trials of its vaccine. Subsequently, Bharat Biotech signed agreements for supplying the vaccines to Brazil and the US. The Chairman and Managing Director of Bharat Biotech Dr. Krishna Ella said "The COVID-19 pandemic has affected humanity at large. Our goal for all vaccines developed at Bharat Biotech is to provide global access to populations that need it the most. We are happy to note that vaccines innovated in India are able to address the public health needs of Brazil."

Hyderabad based Biological E limited, which was already making adjuvants for Johnson and Johnson's vaccine, entered into a partnership with the US Baylor College of Medicine for developing a vaccine candidate to address the novel coronavirus. The clinical trials of this vaccine started in November 2020, and the results of these trials came out in April 2021. The results look promising, and this is a vaccine whose production can easily be scaled, so it could play a major role in addressing the pandemic in the future. Dr. Peter Hotez, professor and dean of the National School of Tropical Medicine at Baylor says, "This vaccine could one day soon fill urgently needed gaps and vaccine supply shortages in Africa, Latin America, and in low-income Asian countries. It's so exciting to partner with BE helping India to provide a vaccine to halt the COVID-19 pandemic globally." Mahima Datla, Managing Director, Biological E added, "We believe that our vaccine candidate will become another effective global COVID-19 vaccine as we move forward into Phase III clinical trials." d

TOUCHLESS TECH

During the unlockdown there was a spurt of technologies that allowed interfacing at a distance

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The January 2021 Issue of Digit magazine covers the intense digitisation and adoption of technologies that took place over the course of the pandemic. During the unlock phases of the pandemic, as things were beginning to open up again, there was a demand for technologies that allowed for contactless temperature checking, identification, tracking of people, and sanitising common touch points such as railings in elevators or the handles of store doors. It was necessary to deploy many of these technologies at scale, where a large number of people were likely to congregate, such as shopping malls, office complexes, and hospitals.

In June 2020, Park+, a company that offers smart parking solutions to corporates, housing societies, and malls came up with a solution for malls that allowed visitors to register themselves using a QR code and book a shopping window on one of the stores. Stores within the mall can be tagged as red or green depending on the number of customers shopping at the moment, making sure that everyone can visit the store they want to when it is safest to do so.

Amit Lakhotia, ex VP of PayTM, Founder & CEO, Park+ explains, "considering all the aspects of safety and hygiene within malls, we have created a host of services that will help malls enforce social distancing practices, manage customer expectations, and comply with government regulations. Park+ solutions for malls have been designed considering public health and convenience in the battle against COVID-19. The offerings do not entail app installation for customers, boosting the ease of adoption. On the other hand, it does not include expensive hardware installation for malls, making for a simple solution that ensures business continuity in the era of social distancing. Furthermore, it allows customers to plan their shopping trips and avoid long queues outside stores and contact tracing in case of a positive COVID-19 case within the mall premises."

Vistan NextGen, a Hyderabad based robotics startup announced its Flunkey line of service robots in January 2021, including robots made for the education, banking and hospitality sectors. The robots of interest though were two robots for hospitals Shushruth and Nightingale, named after famous figures in medical history. Both these robots are designed for patients visiting doctors. Shushruth